

CASE TITLE: The Midnight Pier Fire DATE: July 15, 2026 OFFICER IN CHARGE: Detective Leo Vance

SUMMARY: At 2345 hours, emergency services responded to a structural fire at Pier 42. While the blaze was contained, the primary office of 'Maritime Logistics' was destroyed. Arson is suspected due to the presence of chemical accelerants.

SUSPECTS:

1. Gregory Vance: A disgruntled dockworker terminated forty-eight hours prior to the incident.
2. Linda Sterling: The CFO of Maritime Logistics. Currently under investigation for internal embezzlement.
3. Marcus Thorne: A local real estate developer who has repeatedly attempted to purchase the pier for luxury condos.

WITNESS STATEMENTS:

1. Gregory Vance: "I was at a bar five blocks away from the pier all night. Check the tabs; I didn't leave my stool until the sirens started."
2. Marcus Thorne: "I was on my yacht, anchored two miles offshore. I saw the smoke from the horizon and called it in immediately."

PHYSICAL CLUES:

- A melted plastic gasoline canister found near the office's ventilation intake.
- A distinctive gold-plated lighter with the initials 'L.S.' recovered from the debris near the north exit.
- Traces of high-grade marine diesel on a pair of discarded work boots found in a nearby dumpster.

SUSPICIOUS DETAILS: The timeline provided by Marcus Thorne is physically impossible. Meteorological records for that evening indicate a heavy fog rolled in at 2300 hours, reducing visibility to less than fifty yards. He could not have seen the smoke from two miles away. Furthermore, while the lighter points toward Linda Sterling, the north exit where it was found had been welded shut for maintenance months ago, making it an unlikely escape route for a legitimate employee.

